

Vanitas

From the Latin word for vanity, a vanitas describes a type of still life painting symbolizing the brevity of life and transience of worldly pleasures. Reminding viewers of their mortality and the worthlessness of worldly amusements, vanitas paintings were first seen in the medieval period, but became particularly popular in Flanders and the Netherlands in the 16th and 17th centuries. Ordinary objects were depicted, so viewers understood the connections immediately. They included symbols of art and science, such as books, maps and musical instruments; wealth and power, such as purses, jewellery and gold; earthly pleasures, such as goblets, pipes and playing cards; and death or transience, such as skulls, clocks and burning candles. Occasionally artists included symbols of resurrection and eternal life, such as ears of corn or sprigs of ivy or laurel. Harmen Steenwyck (1612–56) from Delft, is credited with the invention of the vanitas at this time. His paintings, in minutely realistic detail, show varied textures and light. Other vanitas painters included Jan Davidsz de Heem, (1606–84) and Willem Claesz Heda (c.1594–1680).



Steenwyck, *Vanitas*, c.1640